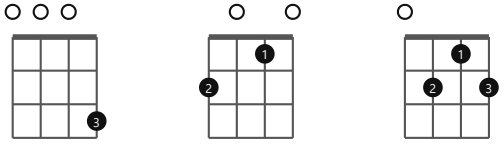
Brahms' Lullaby

Johannes Brahms, 1868

Key: **C major** Time: **3/4** Tempo: **80 bpm** Strum: **D>DD** Starts on: **C (I)** First note: **E**

THE CHORDS IN C, AND HOW THEY FEEL



C
I
home

F
IV
away

G7
V7
tension (wants to go home)

THE SONG

A
Verse
Lullaby, and good...

- The three-chord trick: just one, four and five.
- 1 part in the song, but only 1 different chord pattern to learn.

CHORD MAP

A Verse

Lullaby, and good night, with roses...	**C** I ①	**C** I	**C** I	**G7** V7
lilies o'erspread is baby's wee bed.	**G7** V7	**G7** V7	**G7** V7	**C** I ②
Lay thee down now and rest...	**F** IV	**C** I	**G7** V7	**C** I
Lay thee down now and rest...	**F** IV	**C** I	**G7** V7	**C** I

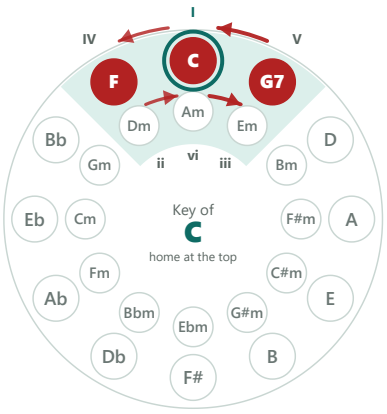
① **Home and away**: C G7 C, I V I, in the line “Lullaby, and good night, with roses...”. Just one and five: home, away, home ("Clementine", "Jambalaya").

② **Three-chord trick**: C F C G7, I IV I V, in the line “lilies o'erspread is baby's wee bed.”. One, four, back home, five: wants to go home again.

CHANGES TO PRACTISE

1. **C → G7** (×3): Slide your ring finger along the A string to the 2nd fret; put your index finger on the E string, 1st fret; put your middle finger on the C string, 2nd fret.
2. **G7 → C** (×3): Slide your ring finger along the A string to the 3rd fret; lift your index finger; lift your middle finger.
3. **C → F** (×2): Put your index finger on the E string, 1st fret; put your middle finger on the G string, 2nd fret; lift your ring finger.
4. **F → C** (×2): Put your ring finger on the A string, 3rd fret; lift your index finger; lift your middle finger.

ON THE CIRCLE OF FIFTHS



- Home is C, ringed at the top. Its closest chords sit either side: IV to the left, V to the right, and the minors ii, vi and iii inside.
- All 3 of its chords sit in the key's family (the shaded part), so it all belongs together.
- C → G7 (I → V7), 3 times: from home out to five: the tension that pulls straight back.
- G7 → C (V7 → I), 3 times: five to one: the strongest pull home.
- C → F (I → IV), 2 times: one step anticlockwise (down a fifth): the way music likes to move.
- F → C (IV → I), 2 times: four to one, the "Amen" sound.

LEARNING IT

1. Practise the hardest changes above until they're smooth (Learn → Changes…).
2. Play along with the chords, then **from memory**: the chords hidden after the first time each part comes, then as numbers only, then none (Learn → From memory).
3. Play it in another key, thinking in numbers. If you can, you know the song, not just the shapes.
4. Come back to it in a day or two, and again in a week.

TROUBLE SPOTS

Made with ukemusic on 6 Nov 2026.